

Center educates people, saves and protects vital birds of prey

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SHELBY — Wings that once carried them through the sky are broken or missing. Their sharp, curved talons can no longer seize prey.

The 73 birds at Charlotte's Carolina Raptor Center serve a life sentence because of irresponsible humans. Permanently injured, they can no longer survive in the wild.

Some were shot. Others, lured to the roadside by rodents feeding in litter on the highway, were hit by a car. A few were "rescued" by people who thought the parents had abandoned their baby birds.

Education of "well-meaning humans" is the center's main goal. The raptors that live at the center serve as living examples for educational programs at the center's amphitheater or in schools or club meetings.

"It makes a difference for kids to get close to the birds," said Deborah Sue Griffin, the center's education director. "If we can give the information and spark an interest — people will care for the birds and work to preserve and protect them."

Griffin has a biology degree from UNC-Charlotte. She has been with the center since it began

in 1980 in the basement of the biology building on the UNCC campus.

Raptors — birds of prey — are important to the environment because they control the pest rodent species, such as rats, mice, squirrels and voles. They also help to keep down the numbers of snakes and lizards.

"Sometimes the children don't like to look at the vultures," Griffin said as she walked up to the cage where a shiny black vulture perched on a bar. As Griffin talked, the big bird turned to look in her direction.

"But I asked them what would happen if the garbage men went on strike," she said. "Well, vultures are nature's garbage men. When the kids realize that, they gain an appreciation for the birds."

Raptors also serve as environmental indicators, said a recent issue of the center's newsletter. This means that when a toxin is in the environment, it shows up in raptors before it shows up in human tissues. This occurs because birds have a much higher metabolism than humans.

Rehabilitation is another part of the center's work. More than 3,500 sick, injured or truly orphaned raptors are brought to the

center by volunteers. In June, there were 115 birds in the rehabilitation area.

Injured birds are examined and treated. Veterinarians donate their time for X-rays and surgery. A bird may spend from a few days to a few weeks in intensive care before it is moved outside to an exercise cage.

The final stage before release is spent in a large flight cage, where the bird is encouraged to fly and build up its flight muscles. An attempt is made to release the bird near the location where it was found, if that is possible and appropriate.

Research is another priority of the center. Hawks are watched each fall during the migration season and the center participates each year in the Midwinter Bald Eagle Census. The center also initiated the Osprey Introduction Project at nearby Lake Norman during the 1980s. Other research projects include raptor food requirements, behavior, prey selection, sexing techniques, pellet analysis and the development of young birds.

In 1989, a pair of golden eagles at the center successfully hatched and raised the first chick in captivity in the southeastern

United States. This young eagle was released in July 1992 in the mountains of Georgia.

Caring for rehabilitating birds and the other raptors who live on the center's 57 acres in Latta Plantation Park takes an army of volunteers.

"We have five staff people and

one half-time staff person," said Pat Marcum, the center's executive director. "Most of the work is done by volunteers. We have 150 on-site volunteers who work at least once a month. Another 100 serve throughout the Carolinas as transport volunteers."

Transport volunteers agree to

pick up injured birds and take them to the center or at least part of the way. There are six transport volunteers in Cleveland County.

Other individuals, scout groups and professionals donate their time to build trails, benches, trash bins, aviaries, cages and the outdoor amphitheater.

